WEEK 1 · BUSINESS LAW (INTERNATIONAL)

Is it legal — or is it right?

Two questions that are not the same — and telling them apart is where this course begins.

TODAY

A diagnostic, not a test. No grade, no wrong answers. We find out how you already reason, learn how the course works, and start the one habit at its centre: seeing every side.

A NOTE ON THIS DECK

Week 1 has no pre-class reading — this deck is your study copy.

Every other week you will read a pre-class deck before the session. This week there is nothing to read in advance, so these slides do double duty: what we work through in the room today, and the record you revisit afterwards. The lines in gold at the foot of a slide mark what can be examined later — the midterm covers Weeks 1–5, and Week 1 counts.

ORIENTATION · THE SHAPE OF THE TERM

You will run a company, every week, for ten weeks.

THE SIMULATION

Your board

Your group governs one cross-border company all term, meeting a new legal problem each week through its eyes.

THE RHYTHM

Four blocks

From next week: a short quiz, a whole-class debate, a board case with AI in a set role, and a live defence — every week, the same shape.

THE POINT

Two skills

Critical thinking first, storytelling second — arguing the same facts well from any side.

THE METHOD

Four moves, every week

Every case in this course is worked with the same four-move spine: **name what's really being decided → find the line → weigh both lenses → decide with conditions**. Each week dresses the four moves in that week's law. You will run them for the first time today — without being told you are doing it.

THE ASSESSMENT

Nothing today counts

Weekly quizzes and in-class board cases (each best 6 of 8), a midterm on Weeks 1–5, and a final-week capstone: a live, paired negotiation with **no AI and no computers**. There is no final exam. Today is ungraded — deliberately.

WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

The law you will use in your career will have changed by the time you get there. The **method** — reading facts closely, arguing every side, deciding with reasons — will not. This course grades the method.

Testable: the weekly rhythm is quiz → debate → board case (AI in a declared role) → live defence; the master method is the same four moves every week — name the decision, find the line, weigh both lenses, decide with conditions; there is no final exam, and the capstone is a paired negotiation with AI prohibited.

ORIENTATION · THE CAST

One of these companies is yours by the end of today.

COMPANY	HOME	TRADITION	WHAT IT DOES
Maison Calère	France	CIVIL	Artisanal leather goods
Aevum Robotics	Germany	CIVIL	Industrial automation
Vireo Therapeutics	Switzerland	CIVIL	Early-stage biotech
Terra Verde Logística	Brazil	CIVIL	Freight & supply chain
Kaze Energy	Japan	CIVIL	Battery & clean energy
Pulse Health	United Kingdom	COMMON	Digital health & data
Halcyon Studios	United States	COMMON	AI-driven media
Keystone Pay	Singapore	COMMON	Cross-border payments
Surya Apparel	India	COMMON	Textiles & apparel export
Sahar AgriTech	DIFC, Dubai	COMMON	Agri-technology & water

WHAT THE TWO COLUMNS IN THE MIDDLE ARE FOR

Five of these companies live in the **civil-law** world and five in the **common-law** world — the two great legal traditions. You do not need to know the difference today. Next week it becomes the difference that explains almost everything.

Testable: each board governs one company from a fixed roster of ten for the whole term; the roster is split five civil-law and five common-law by home jurisdiction; every weekly case reaches the room through your own company's eyes.

ORIENTATION · AI IN A DECLARED ROLE

AI is a partner you out-think — never a substitute for thinking.

THE RULE

Always a declared role

Each week AI has one job — this week and next, a **research assistant** that gathers and organises. The role changes as the term hardens: later it will argue against you, map rights, scout enforcement. In the final session it is barred from the room entirely, with one declared role left in preparation only.

THE HABIT

Ask AI, then disagree

Every week from Week 2 you write a short paragraph, **by hand** (150–200 words): what AI said, and where you push back — where it was wrong, thin, or overconfident. The judgement stays yours, and the paragraph is individually assessed.

WHY THE RULES ARE STRICT

Not because the tool is forbidden — because **undeclared use teaches you nothing and declared use teaches you everything**. The course's bet is that after ten weeks of using AI in its lane and disagreeing with it in writing, you can out-think it. The capstone tests exactly that.

Testable: AI always operates in one declared role per week, beginning as research assistant; the weekly "Ask AI, then disagree" paragraph is handwritten, 150–200 words, individually assessed, and runs from Week 2; at the Week 10 capstone AI is prohibited in the room.

ORIENTATION · THE PROMISE

From next week, your board gets a file.

THE DOSSIER

Your company's own dispute

A file about your company: how the fight started, where things stand, and what people are saying — told by partisan voices, never a neutral narrator. Nobody in the file is objective. Reading past that is your job.

THE CONTRACT FILE

Two clauses, read word by word

Every dossier carries two verbatim contract extracts. One of them is the clause the fight is actually about. The other is a trap — plausible, professional, and not the point. Telling them apart takes reading, not guessing.

THE QUESTIONS

Withheld until the laptops close

You research with AI in its declared role — but the questions you must answer arrive on paper only after devices are away. What you did not genuinely understand, you cannot answer.

THE MORNING TWIST

Something happens on the day

Each case carries a development printed only on the questions page — new that morning, impossible to prepare for. Your analysis has to survive it live.

WHY IT IS BUILT THIS WAY

Every mechanism above exists for one reason: **so that the work AI can do for you is never the work that is marked.** The tool can gather; it cannot read your file closely, sit in your board's chair, or defend a judgement out loud. That part was always going to be you.

Testable: a case week's dossier is told by partisan voices with no neutral narrator; it carries two verbatim contract extracts of which one is a decoy; the questions are withheld until devices are away; and a morning development, printed only on the questions page, must be answered live.

DIAGNOSTIC · NORTHWIND INDUSTRIES

Northwind's plant discharges an effluent into the river that runs past it. Where the plant sits, the discharge is entirely legal — permitted, monitored, within local limits, and standard practice among local rivals. In Northwind's home country, the same discharge is banned as harmful, and it is banned in several others. No regulator forces Northwind's hand: the local law simply permits what the home law forbids. Downstream, a community lives with the river it is given. A junior manager inside the plant has now objected — not in court, because there is nothing to sue over, but to the board, in writing, on conscience.

— The board must decide what to do. So must you.

DISCUSS

It is legal. Is that the end of the matter — or only the beginning? Take a first position before we open it up.

HOLD THIS CASE

Northwind returns at the very end of this course, in Week 10, when the same shape — **lawful, profitable, and paid for by people who are not in the room** — appears again with real money on the table. What you say today is the baseline you will be measured against, by yourself.

DIAGNOSTIC · WHAT THE DILEMMA IS REALLY ASKING

One decision, three questions that run the whole course.

Sources of law

Where does the rule that "permits" this even come from? Law is not weather — every rule has an origin: a statute passed by a legislature, a constitution above it, a regulator's standard, a court's decision, or long custom. Naming the source is the first step in knowing how solid a rule is, and who could change it.

Legal systems

Why is the same discharge legal in one country and banned in another? Because countries answer the same question through different legal machinery — and a company operating across borders cannot simply pick the answer it prefers. Week 2 installs the two great traditions behind this disagreement.

Law & morality

Is "legal" the same as "right"? A valid law tells you what you may do; it has never fully answered what you should. The gap between the two is where every hard decision in this course lives — and where Northwind's board is standing now.

KEEP THE THREE APART

"Where does the rule come from?", "whose rule applies?", and "is the rule enough?" are **three different questions**. Most bad arguments about Northwind come from answering one while believing you have answered another.

Testable: the three foundation questions are sources of law (every rule has an identifiable origin — statute, constitution, regulation, case law, custom), legal systems (different countries lawfully answer the same question differently), and law versus morality (a law can be valid and still not settle what one should do).

BLOCK C · LAPTOPS OPEN — AI IN ITS FIRST DECLARED ROLE

Before you take a seat at Northwind's table, find out what the world already knows.

TASK 1

The practice

How common is it for an industrial practice to be lawful in one country and banned in another? Find one real example — any industry — and note who defended it, and how.

TASK 2

The argument

Find the argument, made famous by Martin Luther King, that a law can be valid and still be unjust. Put it in your own words — one sentence. Do not copy his.

TASK 3

The company

Find one real company that stopped doing something legal because it judged the practice wrong — or one that did not, and paid for it later. What actually moved the decision?

HOW TO USE THE TOOL — THE COURSE'S WAY, FROM DAY ONE

Ask AI to **gather and organise**: examples, arguments, background. Then do the part it cannot: decide what the material means for Northwind. Notice, as you work, where the tool is confident and thin at the same time — that observation is the seed of the "Ask AI, then disagree" habit you start next week. **When the briefs are handed out, devices go away and stay away.**

BLOCK D · ONE PAGE PER GROUP, HANDED OUT NOW

Six seats at Northwind's table. You will argue from one of them — not as a lens, as a person.

SEAT 1

Senior management

You built this plant, you answer to the owners, and everything you do is lawful. The objection threatens jobs, contracts, and a plant that follows every rule it is given.

SEAT 2

The junior manager

You saw the discharge figures and the home-country ban side by side, and you raised it. You have a career, a mortgage, and a conscience — and only one of them is in writing.

SEAT 3

The community downstream

You live with the river Northwind leaves you. Nobody asked you, nobody compensates you, and the law of your own country says nothing wrong is happening.

SEAT 4

The home-country regulator

Your country banned this discharge because the evidence said harm. Now a company that calls your country home does abroad what it may not do at home — lawfully.

SEAT 5

The ethicist

You are asked the question everyone else is avoiding: not "is it legal?" but "is it right?" — and you must answer it without pretending the law does not exist.

SEAT 6

The journalist

You hold the story. Print it, and jobs may go and the plant may close. Sit on it, and the river stays as it is. Your duty is to the truth — but which telling of it?

TEN GROUPS, SIX SEATS — FOUR SEATS ARE DOUBLED, ON PURPOSE

Two groups holding the **same seat** will reach the debrief with **different reasoning**. When that happens — and it will — you have seen the deepest thing this course teaches: a perspective is not an answer. It is a place to reason from.

Testable: the Week 1 diagnostic runs six stakeholder seats — senior management, the objecting junior manager, the downstream community, the home-country regulator, the ethicist, and the journalist; seats are argued as people with stakes, not as abstract positions; with ten groups four seats are deliberately doubled.

BLOCK D · EVERY SEAT ANSWERS THE SAME FOUR

Different chairs, identical questions. That is what makes the answers comparable.

1 · Read it from your seat

What does this decision look like from where you sit? What do you know that the others do not — and what can you not see from your chair?

2 · Legal versus right

From your seat: is "it's legal" the end of the matter? Say precisely what the law settles for you — and what it leaves open.

3 · Whose rule

The host country permits; the home country forbids. Which rule should govern a company that lives in both worlds — and why yours?

4 · Commit — and price it

Say what Northwind should do. No fence-sitting. Then say, honestly, what your choice costs and who pays it — every option here has a bill.

THE STANDARD

A strong answer argues the seat **at its strongest**, even if you privately disagree with it — and names the best objection against it before someone else does. Committing with a price attached beats hedging every time. That standard never changes for the next nine weeks.

Testable: every brief carries the same four questions — read it from your seat, legal versus right, whose rule, and commit while naming what the choice costs; fence-sitting is disallowed, and a position argued at its strongest with its best objection named is the course's standard of a good answer.

DIAGNOSTIC · WHERE THE ROOM TURNS

"It's legal" against "legal isn't right" — staged as two people, not two slogans.

SEAT 1 · SENIOR MANAGEMENT

The letter of the law

A company obeys the law of each place it operates — no more, no less. It should not impose one country's values on another that has lawfully chosen differently. If the discharge is permitted here, the matter is closed. There is certainty in that, humility even, and a clear line of accountability: change the law, and we will follow it.

SEAT 2 · THE JUNIOR MANAGER · THE ANCHOR

The moral view

The argument Martin Luther King pressed: a law can be perfectly valid and still be unjust, and "it was allowed" has never excused everything that was once allowed. Permission is not obligation — nothing forces Northwind's hand but its own choices. A company has a conscience because its people do, and one of them is saying so out loud.

THE INSIGHT TO HOLD

Both seats carry a real worry — imposing values on another country (Seat 1) and hiding behind permission (Seat 2). They are answering **different questions**: what may we do, and what should we do. The whole course lives in the gap between those questions, and the skill is arguing both honestly before choosing.

Testable: the anchor of Week 1 is the distinction between a valid law and a just one — the argument associated with Martin Luther King; "legal" answers what a company may do while "right" asks what it should do; both poles of the tension carry a legitimate concern, and they are different questions rather than opposite answers.

DEBRIEF · FILL THE SPACE BETWEEN THE POLES

Four more seats speak — and the doubled seats face each other.

The other four seats

- **The community** — bears the cost, holds no vote, and the local law is on Northwind's side
- **The home regulator** — banned it for a reason, and watches it continue under a flag of convenience
- **The ethicist** — must answer "is it right?" without wishing the law away
- **The journalist** — every version of the truth moves the outcome, including silence

The skill on show

- Inhabiting a person you are not — stakes, fears, blind spots and all
- Giving reasons, not just conclusions
- Answering the hardest objection before it is asked
- Doubled seats: hearing your own seat reasoned differently — and saying what the difference is

WATCH WHAT THE DOUBLING DOES

When two groups hold the same seat, the room discovers that the seat did not dictate the reasoning. **The same chair produced two different arguments.** Hold onto that: it means every position you will ever be handed in this course — and after it — is a starting point, not a script.

Testable: the remaining seats bring the community that bears the cost, the regulator whose ban is evaded lawfully, the ethicist who must reason with the law rather than around it, and the journalist whose choice of telling shapes the outcome; the doubled seats demonstrate that a seat constrains the stakes but not the reasoning.

DIAGNOSTIC · THE READ

Legal and right came apart — and reasonable people landed in different places.

The distinction held

"It's legal" turned out not to settle "what should we do?" Nobody in the room could hold the two questions together as one — because they are not one.

Systems disagreed

The same discharge, lawful here and banned there — and no seat could make that disagreement disappear. Week 2 explains where it comes from.

You argued every side

Seats you did not choose, positions you do not hold — argued at their strongest, priced honestly. The course's skill, on day one, before any law was taught.

WHAT WAS NOT REVEALED

A right answer about Northwind. There is not one on offer today, and the course will not hand you one in Week 10 either. What it will hand you is a method for deciding — and the obligation to own what you decide.

Testable: the diagnostic's three findings are that legal and right are separable questions, that legal systems lawfully disagree about the same act, and that a position can be argued at its strongest by someone who does not hold it; the diagnostic deliberately ends without a verdict on Northwind.

ORIENTATION · THE REVEAL

The four questions on your brief were the course's method, unnamed.

Read it from your seat

was **Move 1 — name what's really being decided.** Before anything else: what is actually the question, and for whom?

Legal versus right

was **Move 2 — find the line.** Locate exactly what the rule settles and where it stops — the line between what is answered and what is still open.

Whose rule

was **Move 3 — weigh both lenses.** Two legitimate framings of the same facts, held up honestly against each other before choosing.

Commit, and price it

was **Move 4 — decide with conditions.** A position, its cost, and who pays — never a verdict pretending to be free.

FROM NEXT WEEK

Each week dresses these four moves in that week's law — and from the drafting weeks onward, the fourth move sharpens into something harder: fixing, in writing, the thing that failed. Same spine, ten different bodies. By Week 10 you will run it from blank paper, from memory, with no machine in the room.

Testable: the master method is four moves — name what's really being decided, find the line, weigh both lenses, decide with conditions; Week 1's four brief questions are this method in plain words; each subsequent week specialises the same four moves to its own doctrine.

WEEK 1 · WHERE WE STARTED

Today, "legal" and "right" came apart in your hands, and you argued Northwind's decision from six chairs that were not yours. That is the whole course in miniature: see clearly, weigh honestly, argue every side, then choose — and know the difference between what the law allows and what you owe.

The law told Northwind what it could do. It could not tell Northwind what it should.

CARRY IT

Next week: you saw that countries disagree about the same act. Why? Because the world runs on two great legal traditions — civil law and common law — and Week 2 installs the difference that explains almost everything that follows. Come with your company chosen. The four-block rhythm begins, and the first "Ask AI, then disagree" paragraph is due.

ONE MORE THING ABOUT NORTHWIND

Keep your answer from today somewhere you can find it. In Week 10, with money on the table and your own signature at stake, you will meet this exact shape again — and the only person checking whether your answer changed will be you.